the Gandhi-Irwin Pact (1931) that he had negotiated. Those who claim that the Mahatma could not, as a matter of principle, have insisted that the pact would stand dishonoured on the part of Lord Irwin if Bhagat Singh was not released fail to recognize that the agreement between Gandhi and Irwin required the withdrawal and consequent nullification of the emergency ordinances. If Gandhi did try to intervene on behalf of Bhagat Singh, but not determinedly enough so as to actually insist on his release, then that made all the difference between securing his freedom from the gallows and seeing him hang.

When Bose and Gandhi arrived in New Delhi from Bombay, Bose proceeds to describe how 'we received a bombshell in the shape of news, to the effect that the government had decided to execute Sardar Bhagat Singh and two of his comrades in the Lahore conspiracy case'. In the circumstances, therefore, '[p]ressure was brought to bear upon the Mahatma to try to save the lives of these young men and *it must be admitted that he did try his very best*' (emphasis added). Bose then goes on to say, 'I ventured the suggestion that he should, if necessary, break with the Viceroy on the question, because the execution was against the spirit, if not the letter, of the Delhi Pact.' Bose had good reason to take this line, because as he recollected, 'I was reminded of the similar incident during the Armistice between the Sinn Fein party and the British government, when the strong attitude adopted by the former, had secured the release of Irish political prisoners sentenced to the gallows.' However, the fact that Bose then adds the proviso that '*[b]ut the Mahatma did not want to identify himself with the revolutionary business*, (emphasis added)' only serves to confirm that the Mahatma did not in fact wish to go any further than he had already done. This casts doubt on Bose's own earlier statement that the Mahatma 'did try his very best' which plainly he did not if Gandhi was not prepared to break with the Viceroy on the question of those sentenced to the gallows as Bose had exhorted him to. Indeed, Bose was clear that the Mahatma '*would not go so far and naturally that made a great difference when the Viceroy realised that the Mahatma would not break on that question*'[13] (emphases added). This is the clearest evidence from Bose about what the Mahatma